getting it signed by all my team-mates. It now has pride of place in the cellar at my house.

We tried to make the most of the moment in as many different ways as possible. We took countless photographs. First it was the players, then we took some with Gary, who had just served out his last match as India coach. Paddy Upton and Mike Horn, both important members of our support unit, soon joined in and it seemed toally acceptable for adults to behave like children.

As my team-mates were posing with the trophy one by one, I remember wandering out of the dressing room to soak up the atmosphere. It seemed that not a single soul had left the ground. People were busy capturing every possible angle on their mobile phones. I saw Sudhir Gautam, now a familiar face in India as the man who paints his body with the tricolour and paints my surname and number ‘10’ on it, blowing his conch at full blast. The noise from his conch and the sound of the firecrackers blended together to create quite an atmosphere. It felt surreal.

I waved at Sudhir Gautam to come and join us inside the dressing room. He was startled to see me do so, to say the least. For him it was totally unexpected. It was already a night to remember for us; his was about to become even more memorable. I asked the security personnel to allow him into the dressing room and passed him the trophy to hold. He was overwhelmed. I felt a deep sense of satisfaction at being able to make him so happy. He had travelled with us all the way through the World Cup and it was our way of showing him and the rest of our fans that we cared. I only wish I could have let every supporter at the Wankhede pose with the trophy.

The players’ families soon joined in the celebrations and I remember trying to explain to Arjun and Sara the significance of the World Cup for a cricketer. I told them it was the pinnacle and could never be surpassed. Almost two hours after the victory, we finally left for the hotel. The normally short journey from the stadium to the hotel was one of the slowest but also one of the best of my life. While I had not seen a soul on my way to the ground in the morning, on the way back there was a sea of humanity and the journey took almost an hour.

Marine Drive was quite a sight. Although I remember dancing and celebrating as a kid after India’s first World Cup win in 1983, the memory is a bit of a blur. This was our moment. It was liberation. I had